

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: U.S. Navy photo

America launched new strikes on **Iran**, but claimed they were “purely defensive”. US Central Command said its forces had shot down drones launched from southern **Iran**. The Islamic Republic said it had targeted an “American airbase” but did not specify where. In a new statement Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, Iran’s supreme leader, called for national unity. He did not mention recent attacks or talks with America.

Binyamin Netanyahu said he directed **Israel’s** armed forces to seize at least 70% of **Gaza**. The prime minister’s order would violate a ceasefire agreement that America brokered in October, in which Israel agreed to leave just over half of the enclave occupied. Meanwhile, Israel continued striking southern **Lebanon**. Hizbullah and Israel accused each other of repeatedly breaking their truce.

Anthropic dethroned **OpenAI** as the world’s most valuable AI startup after securing \$65bn in funding at a valuation of \$900bn. The San Francisco-headquartered company, which was founded in 2021, has more than doubled its previous valuation of \$380bn in February. OpenAI was valued at \$852bn following a funding round that closed in April—a milestone which took around a decade to reach.

America's ^{PCE} price index—the Federal Reserve's preferred **inflation** gauge—rose by 3.8% year on year in April. Soaring food and energy costs because of the Iran war pushed prices to their highest level since May 2023. That is weighing on economic growth: new data, released separately, indicates that America's ^{GDP} grew by less than expected in the first quarter.

Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, agreed to buy 20 modern fighter planes on a visit to **Sweden**. Last year Ukraine signed a letter of intent to buy up to 150 of the new Gripen model ^E jets. Until it can buy the rest, the country will also receive 16 older planes. Earlier Mr Zelensky appealed to America for more air-defence systems to [counter attacks by Russia](#).

Tilman Fertitta, a hospitality billionaire, agreed to buy **Caesars Entertainment**, a casino giant, for \$31 a share. The deal, worth a transaction value of \$17.6bn including debt, values Caesars' equity at \$5.7bn. Mr Fertitta, an ally of Mr Trump, is America's ambassador to Italy. He owns Golden Nugget casinos, the ^{NBA}'s Houston Rockets and restaurant chains such as Rainforest Cafe and Morton's.

The **European Commission** fined **Temu**, a Chinese online marketplace, €200m (\$232m) for selling illegal products, such as baby toys and chargers that do not meet safety standards. It is the largest fine issued under the bloc's Digital Services Act, introduced in 2022 to regulate online platforms. Temu said it disagreed with the fine, which it called "disproportionate".

Figure of the day: 159%. The growth in operating profits at South Korea's biggest companies over the past year. This is [thanks chiefly to the country's high-tech exporters](#).



Photograph: EPA

Why China is courting Serbia

Serbia's president, Aleksandar Vucic, will finish his first state visit to China on Thursday after five days of pomp. The Balkan country will have drawn more attention from Chinese officials since Viktor Orban was **voted out** as Hungary's prime minister on April 12th. The populist Mr Orban had been China's staunchest supporter in an increasingly China-sceptic European Union. Mr Vucic, whose country is applying to join the EU, is another Chinese cheerleader.

On Monday Xi Jinping, China's premier, awarded him the golden "Friendship Medal"—an honour also bestowed on Vladimir Putin, Russia's president, and Raúl Castro, Cuba's de facto leader. But Mr Vucic is discovering, as Mr Orban did, that popularity in Beijing does not necessarily boost it at home. Protesters roiled Belgrade as he set off for China. Their demands include clarity about Serbia's infrastructure-building projects, in which China is a major partner.

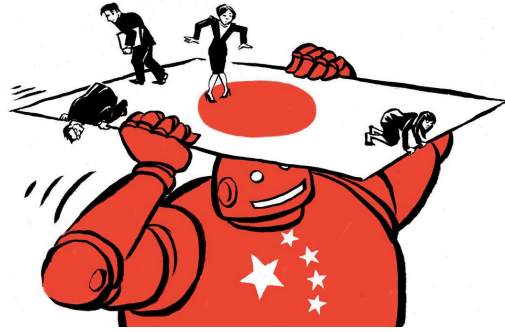


Illustration: David Simonds

Tokyo's battle of the bots

Humanoid robots can dance and back-flip to amuse in viral videos. But the [big question is whether they can replace human labour](#). The Humanoids Summit, which opened on Thursday in Tokyo, will make the case that they can. For two days researchers, policymakers and companies such as Google DeepMind, an artificial-intelligence firm, and Toyota, a carmaker, will extol the virtues of humanoid robots, whether imbued with AI or merely mechanical.

Japan, where an ageing population and chronic labour shortages have made automation a national priority, is a particularly appropriate venue. It created the first humanoid robot back in the 1970s, and has long led the industry. But [China](#) has since stolen the lead. It produced 90% of humanoid robots shipped last year. Japan Airlines, the country's flagship carrier, recently announced a trial in which it will use automatons to load and unload cargo. They are all built by Chinese firms.



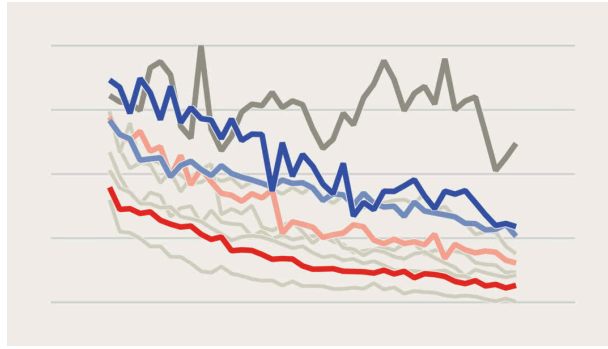
Photograph: AP

The NBA plays to win

Have this year's playoffs in North America's National Basketball Association been unusually gripping? Or do they just feel that way because all the players are actually trying? [Misaligned incentives](#) have made much of the league's long regular season—which determines which teams make the championship playoffs and where they are seeded—increasingly [hard to watch](#).

The NBA determines the selection order for its annual draft of incoming players through a lottery. The teams with the worst records get the best odds of receiving the first pick. Unsurprisingly, many clubs have responded by “tanking” (intentionally losing games) to improve their chances of drafting a future superstar.

That practice could finally be ended on Thursday, when the league is expected to pass an anti-tanking reform. The three teams with the most losses will get just two balls in the lottery, compared with three for clubs above them. Like teams facing relegation in European football, the NBA's stragglers might be encouraged to play harder.



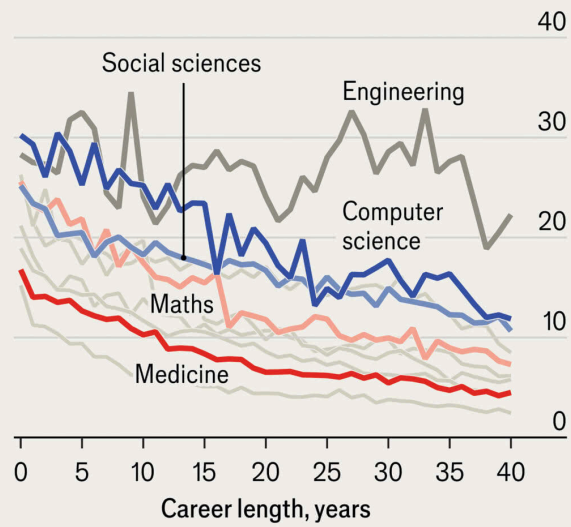
Photograph:

Data bite: Why science is becoming less innovative

In 2023, an influential study found that science was [producing fewer breakthroughs](#) than it once had. A new paper helps explain why. Research led by the University of Pittsburgh analysed the careers of 12.5m scientists who published papers between 1960 and 2020. They found that with age most became more likely to build on, rather than challenge, existing theories. In countries with older workforces, such as America and Japan, “disruptive” papers—meaning those introducing novel ideas, assessed using subsequent citations—accounted for a smaller share of research output than in countries whose scientists skewed younger, such as China and India.

Cause a stir

Probability of a scientist producing a top 10% disruptive paper* by discipline, 1960-2020, %



*Based on how often future studies cite a paper without also citing the earlier work it relied on

Source: H. Cui et al., *Science*, 2026



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which philosopher and economist was born in Trier in 1818 and died in London in 1883?

Wednesday: Robert Johnson and Muddy Waters were pioneers in which music genre?

*Where hope rises fear must lurk
behind.*

Anne Brontë